

The Town of Sebago Transfer Station: An In-Depth Analysis

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Introduction

The Town of Sebago's Transfer Station is on a track to success and slowly becoming more efficient and modernized. However, it's undeniable that the transfer station is currently inefficient, described as a "money pit" that ineffectively uses the town's money (Plante). In 2023, it cost the town \$247,050 to run the transfer station, in 2024 these expenses jumped \$84,168 to \$331,218 (Town Records). Needless to say, the Town's transfer station is an important budget concern that needs to be addressed.

Before diving into the research, one first needs to understand that it's unrealistic that every recommendation described could be instantly implemented. Rather, "the best way to make any progress at a transfer station is to make a list to pick away at" (Jennings). Additionally, any proposed changes must of course be first presented to the employees of the transfer station and the Select Board to ensure they are viable.

Survey Data Analysis

An in-person survey conducted with 107 respondents revealed several key issues with the current operations of the Sebago transfer station. Notably, 35 respondents indicated that there was nothing to change, highlighting satisfaction among many users. However, the remaining responses identified significant areas for improvement. The main categories of concern discussed were space, equipment, and "other." I later posed a secondary question asking if the Town should implement a scale for bulky waste. Out of 56 respondents, the response was nearly 50/50 with a slight majority voting "no." This suggests that Sebago residents are evenly split on the issue of implementing a scale or not.

Figure 1

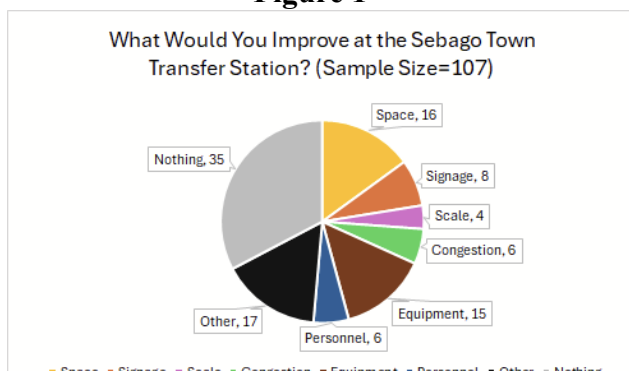
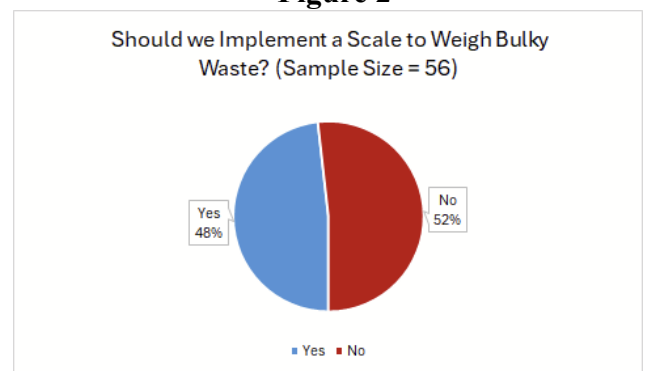


Figure 2



It's important to keep in mind that there were some unavoidable accuracy issues with the in-person survey data, however this doesn't completely discredit the information gained from these surveys. Chiefly, it was difficult to create a set of categories for improvement, which resulted in the necessity of the "other" category for all the suggestions that didn't fit under one of the express categories like "personnel" or "equipment." The most common issues discussed in the "other" category were suggestions regarding cost-cutting and scheduling; in light of this, I included these categories in a subsequent online survey.

Figure 3

How satisfied are you with the current operations of the Sebago transfer station? (1 very unsatisfied, 2 unsatisfied, 3 neutral, etc.)

161 responses

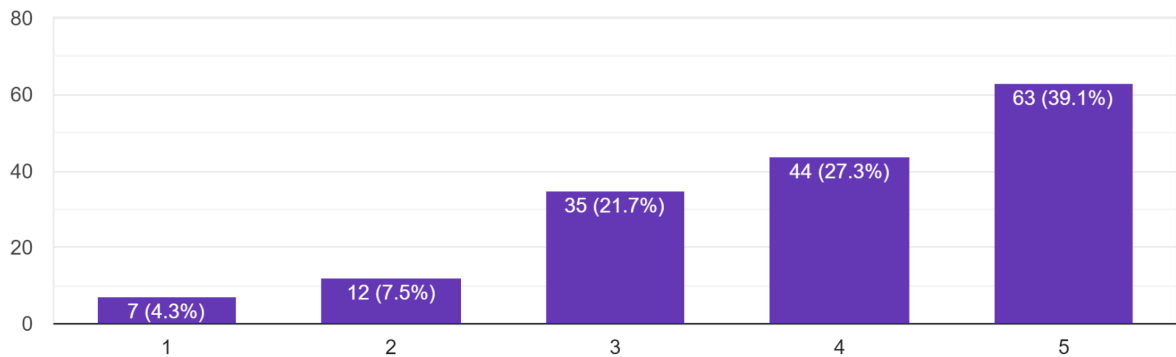


Figure 4

Do you support the idea of adding a scale to sort our bulky waste by weight? We currently have workers on site that estimate the price but a scale would make sure everyone pays their fair share. It's a large upfront cost (75,000 - 150,000\$) but would pay for itself in the long term.

161 responses

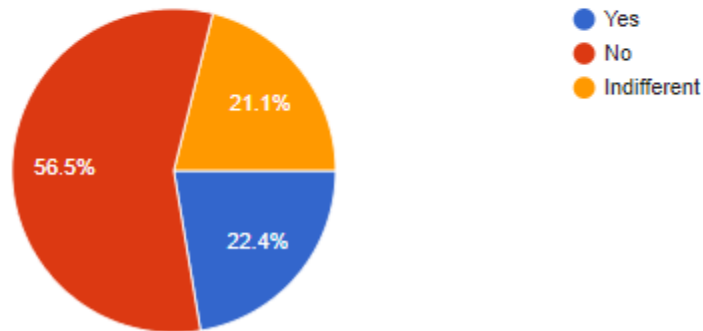
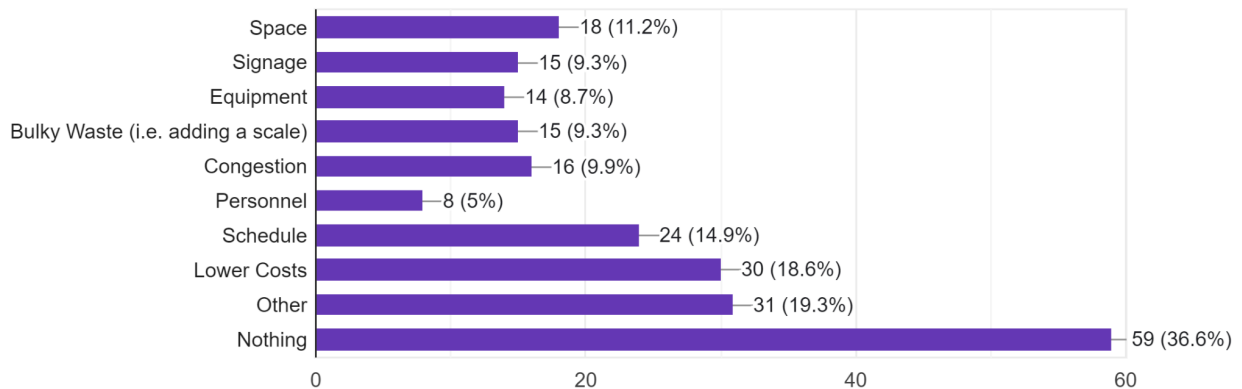


Figure 5

What do you feel needs the most improvement at the Sebago town transfer station? (You may select multiple answers.)

161 responses



Compared to the in-person survey results, the online survey results tell a different story. Like the in-person results, most respondents expressed satisfaction with the operations of the transfer station with 39.7% rating it a 5/5. However, where the online survey differed from the in-person survey is with respect to the question of a scale, with 55.7% of respondents saying they didn't want a scale, 22.1% of respondents indifferent about a scale, and a very small portion of pro-scale townspeople. When it came to improvements in the transfer station, 37.1% of survey respondents said that there was nothing they'd like to change and only 5% of people said that the

transfer station personnel were a problem. The results showed there was a decent amount of concern, however, over costs (17.6%), schedule (15.1%), space (11.3%), and other issues (18.9%).

As with the in-person survey, it's important to consider factors that may have impacted the accuracy of the online survey data. One drawback of the online survey is, like the in person survey, the "other" category is difficult to quantify. Also, no open response questions were included in the online survey in an effort to avoid malicious actors who might take advantage and leave rude responses. Another problem with the online survey is it's more difficult to explain the benefits of a scale online as compared to in-person, which may result in an increased negative response when it comes to implementing a scale. Finally, the same person could submit the survey multiple times, possibly inflating certain values to unrealistic numbers; however, after analyzing the data it appears doubtful that anyone did this to a meaningful extent.

Main Issues Identified

Minimal Space.

The transfer station is constrained by limited space, which hinders the installation of necessary infrastructure such as a weighing scale. Clearing out trees at the entrance and behind the brush pit could alleviate some of these space issues. The transfer station lot is 50.62 acres, but the main constraint comes from the old landfill, a 2.76 acre plot that borders the existing transfer station. This landfill is a problem because it encircles the transfer station, making it difficult to expand. If the Town were to expand, it would be most sensible to clear an area for a brush dump, a process which the Town is currently working on over the next few years.

The current small brush area is a major problem because the Town has to have an employee regularly bring the brush to Bridgton for disposal. Creating a new area for brush would therefore free-up time for this employee to do other things and would also reduce wear-and-tear on the transfer station's truck. If the Town were to expand the brush area, it could take advantage of Cross Excavation, a Bethel-based company that Cumberland and Lovell, Maine both use for brush disposal. Cross chipping removes brush free-of-charge, no money exchanged. Thus, Cross Excavation is an excellent, cost-effective option for future brush removal, when the Town has more space for its brush.

No Weighing, no scale.

Currently, there is no scale at the transfer station, making it difficult to accurately charge for bulky waste. Implementing a scale, despite an initial cost of approximately \$150,000, (Plante) is a long-term investment that could last up to 50 years like the Town of Bridgton's scale. While \$150,000 is a significant expenditure, in reality it would likely raise taxes by less than one percent (1%) for each individual Sebago resident (Genest). The cost varies depending

on the size of the scale. A normal sized, cookie-cutter scale may be less than our estimation. Whereas a large, custom scale could be more than our estimate. A vehicle scale is a large upfront cost but is widely known to be a great long-term investment for towns. The town of Harrison, Maine purchased a scale from Maine Scale for just over \$54,200. The scale became operational in 2015 (Finch). The Harrison Town Manager estimated that the scale paid for itself in approximately two (2) years (Jennings).

Outdated facilities.

The lack of running water, proper restroom facilities, and security are significant issues. Installing these amenities would improve hygiene and employee satisfaction. Out of the seven (7) transfer stations I visited, 6/7 had bathrooms with running water, and 5/7 had security systems. Restroom facilities are a standard among most transfer stations, and it's unhygienic and potentially dangerous to not have access to a bathroom at the transfer station. If one of the Town's personnel got a hazardous substance on them or in their eyes it would be difficult to resolve without access to running water. The town already devotes \$4,000 a year to the portable toilet on-site, why not cut these costs and build a small bathroom? Additionally, the lack of a security system poses a risk of potential break-ins or theft. Finally, a lack of shade at the transfer station makes hot and rainy days hard to bear, expanding the awning over the bulky waste container would be inexpensive and would greatly improve employee comfort. Adding these facilities would greatly improve employee satisfaction as well as make it easier to hire new employees in the future.

Old equipment.

The existing equipment is outdated and prone to breakdowns. For instance, the truck used on-site and to haul brush to Bridgton has around a million miles; at one point, the drive shaft fell off the truck while it was being driven on public roads. Upgrading the on-site truck and other essential machinery is crucial for maintaining operational efficiency and safety. Another technological upgrade that would serve to greatly improve the transfer station would be implementing a Square or Clover payment system so that people could pay by card or Apple Pay instead of cash only. If necessary, a portable hotspot could be implemented to ensure the card reader can function.

Too many freebies.

The practice of allowing free drop-offs for bulky waste is costly. Implementing stricter controls and ensuring that all items are vetted before being accepted could reduce unnecessary expenses. Additionally, there are a fair number of people that drop-off a single small item in the bulky waste bin for which the Town does not charge. In light of this, it might make sense to implement a small flat fee, as these small freebies add-up in the long term.

Another alternative the Town could consider is opening a store off-site where free items are taken and sold. The Town of Bridgton has a store at their transfer station which generates \$2,000 to \$6,000 per month. One consideration with a store, however, is that the Town would likely need to hire a seasonal employee to staff the store. The Town of Waterford has a free area contained in a shed that houses a large amount of items; volunteers come in periodically to organize the space. This may be another option to consider, as the Town currently doesn't have much space to store free items at the transfer station.

We received many suggestions regarding ways Sebago residents can save money at the transfer station. Some of these suggestions include free dump days and coupon books. The town should take these ideas into consideration. Notably, however, both of these ideas would likely prove to be troublesome and inefficient for the transfer station workers and could lead to the town losing money. Free dump days, or days where there's no charge for bulky waste, prove to be incredibly busy and congested days at the transfer station. The Town often has to haul the bulky waste can multiple times, costing about \$300 per trip (Fortier). Considering the amount of money the Town will lose doing a free dump day it doesn't seem sensible unless there was a massive outcry about high prices at the transfer station. Coupon books are a bit of the same. The Town of Bridgton utilized coupon books at one time, and they were an administrative burden for their scale operator. They had to go through a special process each time a customer used a coupon book, leading to increased congestion, and the Town losing money.

Incomplete Signage.

While some new signage has been implemented, more is needed to guide traffic effectively and enhance safety. Improving the visibility of entrance signs can further reduce accidents and confusion. There's also a blind corner in the transfer station near the brush drop off, making potential accidents more likely. Another sign that could prove to be beneficial would be a sign at the garage that describes everything that is stored there, (e.g., paint, lightbulbs, TV's, etc.) This would eliminate confusion and free-up time for transfer station employees to do other tasks instead of directing people in the right direction. It could be helpful to get a sign stating, "No Needles," as transfer station employees have professed concerns over coming in contact with needles in the trash.

Schedule Changes and Hiring.

The schedule at the transfer station is imperfect. Over the winter there's an extremely limited amount of people who utilize the transfer station on a given day. Thus, reducing the transfer station hours over the winter might be sensible. Anthony Shorey and Clyde Secord were hired to work only 20 hours a week, but currently work 30 hours a week. If a new employee were hired, this would alleviate some of Tony and Bill's burden. If the Town implemented a scale it would definitely need another employee at the transfer station.

Proposed Changes to Infrastructure (Ordered from Most to Least Important)

Space Expansion: Clear trees at the entrance and behind the brush pit to create more space for operations and the installation of a weighing scale. The end goal is to create a road leading off from the entrance path that leads to a new brush dump, and would free up a large chunk of space in the transfer station. Limited space was the first issue every employee at the transfer station raised.

If the Town were to expand the brush area, it could take advantage of Cross Excavation, a Bethel-based company that Cumberland and Lovell, Maine both use for brush disposal.

Figure 6



The Cumberland brush dump has a large, open area for brush disposal with clear signage indicating where to dump brush and compostable material. Limited staffing is necessary.

Vehicle Scale Installation: Invest in a vehicle scale to ensure accurate billing for bulky waste, reducing the likelihood of the bulky waste going over budget. The scale would be installed in the space that is currently occupied by the spare waste cans and employee parking lot. The scale house would be next to the scale in clear view, perhaps attached to the existing garage.

Figure 7



Cars navigating around the vehicle scale at Bridgton. If cars don't need to use the scale they simply navigate around the scale house.

Figure 8



A vehicle on the scale at the Bridgton scale house with a customer being assisted by the scale operator.

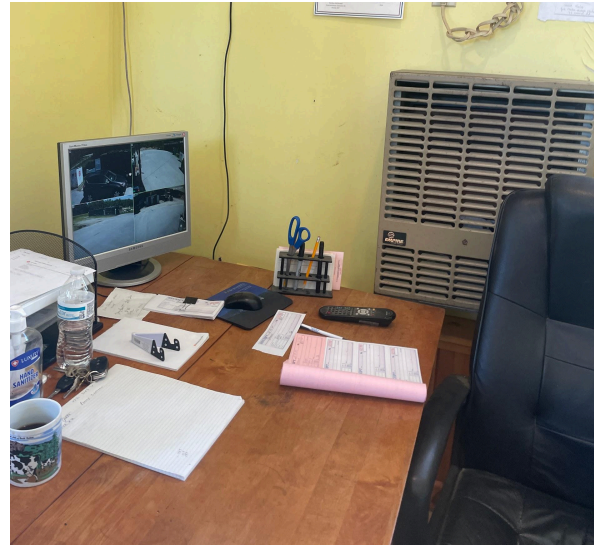
Facility Improvements: Install running water and restroom facilities to improve hygiene and employee satisfaction. Consider installing a shower in the restroom to support clean-up in the event of accidents like chemical spills. Additionally, consider implementing a security system to monitor who comes in-and-out of the transfer station, as well as areas employees can't reliably watch. Finally, expand the awning over the bulky waste so employees can escape the elements.

Figure 9



This garage at the Harrison transfer station features an expansion to the right containing a common room and bathroom.

Figure 10



The Denmark transfer station has a security system viewed on this monitor. A user can view four cameras at once and view footage from up to a month ago.

Equipment Upgrades: Purchase an inexpensive, portable card reader so that those coming into the transfer station can pay with card instead of cash. Square or Clover systems work reliably and are relatively simple and inexpensive. If necessary, purchase a portable hotspot in order to provide internet access to the card reader, although this may not be necessary due to the nearby installation of a fiber internet cable. Last, replace the old truck and other outdated machinery to prevent breakdowns and improve safety. If this isn't feasible, at least prioritize purchasing reliable parts when the truck breaks down.

Figure 11



This Square-powered payment system at the Bridgton scale house might look complicated, but it's basically just an iPad with a card reader attached. I had the opportunity to use their scale and system myself and figured it all out in under 20 minutes. The system also allows for tap-to-pay, which is a great addition.

Enhanced Signage: Increase the visibility and number of signs to guide traffic effectively and enhance safety. Some of the signs at the entrance of the station are difficult to read. Additional signs should be added so that people know where to dispose of different items. Consider a “No Needles” sign for employee well-being.

Figure 12



A great example of signage at the Lovell Transfer Station, clear and easy to read vinyl signs printed on quality boards.

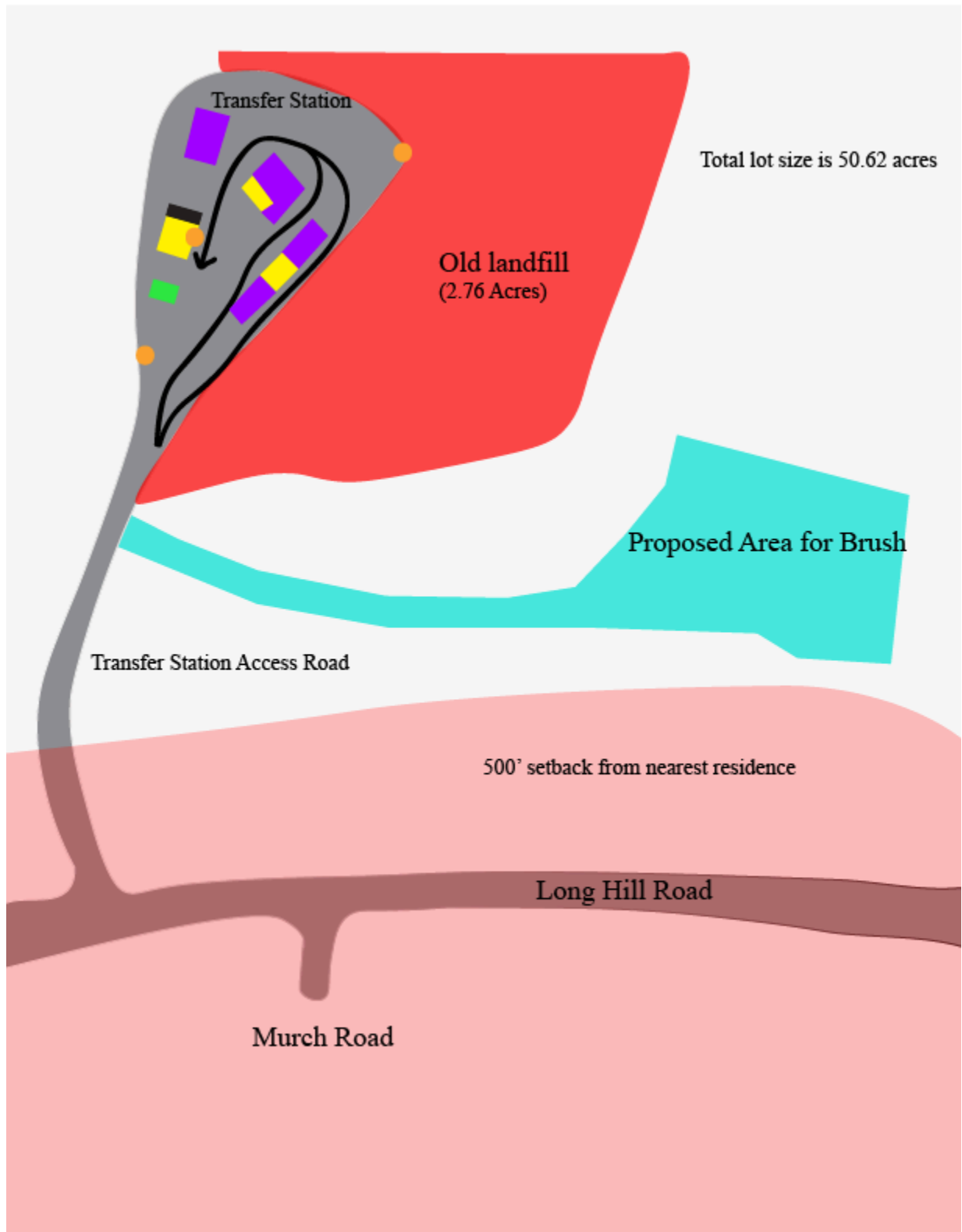
Figure 13



Another good example of signage at Lovell. Clear message and good location.

Freebie Policy Revision: Introduce a vetting process for items dropped off as freebies and ensure all items are approved before being accepted. In other words, take a close look at items coming into the free section at the transfer station so a minimal amount of useless items that people don't want are dropped off.

Figure 14. Map Of Proposed Changes (Not Exact Scale):



Map Key:

Purple = Current dumping areas in the transfer station

Yellow = Current areas where there are buildings

Green = Current employee parking and spare can storage, proposed area for a vehicle scale.

Orange = Proposed areas where security cameras could be placed

Black = Proposed area for a bathroom

Arrows→ = Current traffic flow

Photos of Proposed Areas of Improvement:

Figure 15



View from the area the Town is currently expanding, to the right of the transfer station access road, for a future brush dump.

Figure 16



Current employee parking area and extra can storage. Potential area for a scale house and vehicle scale.

Figure 17



The area to the right of the garage could house a bathroom expansion, especially since the tires have been moved to storage behind the garage.

Figure 18



The bulky waste area has an awning that could be slightly expanded to provide more protection from the elements, improving conditions for both employees and those dumping bulky waste.

Addressing the inefficiencies at the Sebago transfer station is crucial for reducing budget overruns and improving operational efficiency. By expanding space, installing a vehicle scale, revising the freebie policy, upgrading equipment, improving facilities, and improving signage, the Town can significantly enhance the functionality of its transfer station over time.

References

Employee interviews and suggestions, (Anthony Shorey, Clyde “Bill” Secord, David Crawford II, and Fred Fortier.)

George “Bud” Finch, Official Town of Harrison Maine Facebook, references a town meeting.
<https://www.facebook.com/HarrisonMaine/posts/harrison-there-are-changes-coming-to-the-town-s-transfer-station-in-the-coming-we/595867483877808/>

Google Forms and in-person survey results from Sebago residents.

Observations from neighboring towns transfer stations like Cumberland, Bridgton, Denmark, Harrison, Poland, Waterford, Standish, and Lovell. Folder of Photos attached below:
https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1Dn9AYasEsghM9WV8Sbco1z91m8AOl83Q?usp=drive_link

Rich Jennings, employee at the Harrison Town Transfer Station.

Sebago Town Manager Bradley Plante, Town Clerk Letitia Genest.

Sebago Transfer Station Site Plan.